Predicting the full-load power output of a combined cycle power plant

Machine learning regression on 9,527 hours of plant data | ME-446 AI & Internet of Things, Complex Engineering Problem, Fall 2026

NED University of Engineering and Technology, Department of Mechanical Engineering

Shaikh Muhammad Zain

Scan for the live Tableau dashboard

3.45 MW
test RMSE of the selected model (KNN)

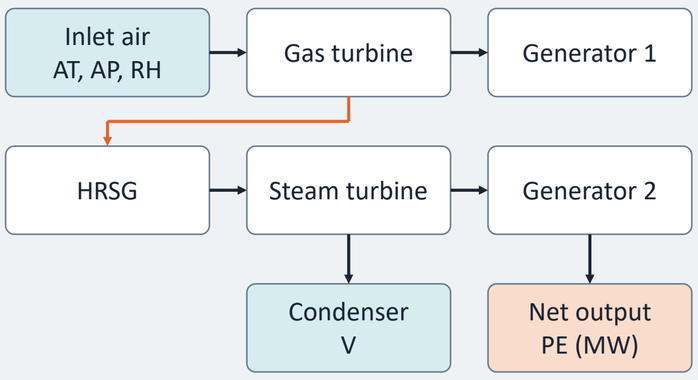
0.540%
test MAPE, against 0.872% in the reference study

0.959
test R^2, against 0.912 in the reference study

9,527
hours of full-load plant data after cleaning

1 The problem

At full load the plant's net output still moves between 420 and 496 MW with the weather. We predict it from four hourly measurements: a supervised regression task.



Teal: measured inputs. Orange: hot exhaust.

- Grid commitment: the plant promises its MW in advance, and over-prediction is penalized.
- Performance monitoring: output below a healthy-plant prediction signals fouling or wear.

2 Data and preprocessing

41 duplicate records dropped, so no hour is in both train and test sets

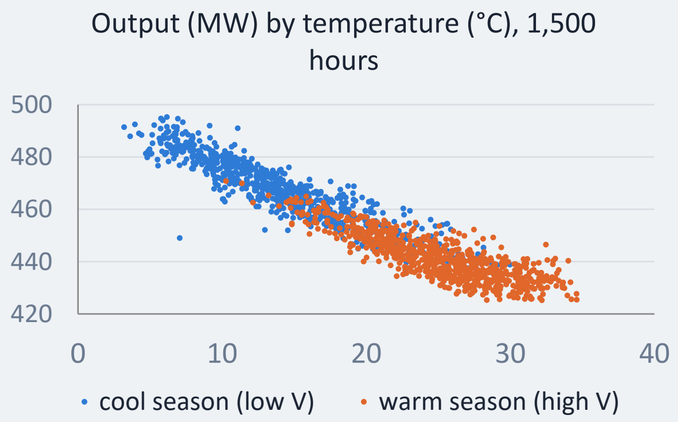
55 humidity readings above 100% capped, rows kept

182 hours with V above air pressure: the unit label is wrong, V kept as an index

0 outliers deleted: they are real weather

Source: UCI Combined Cycle Power Plant dataset, 9,568 hours, 2006 to 2011. Split 80/20 stratified on output; scaler inside the pipeline; tuning by 5-fold cross-validation on training hours; test set used once.

3 Engineering insights



- −2.17 MW per °C; the hottest hours give 52 MW less
- Humid air lowers output at a fixed temperature
- The condenser penalty falls mainly at 15 to 30 °C

4 Three nonlinear models

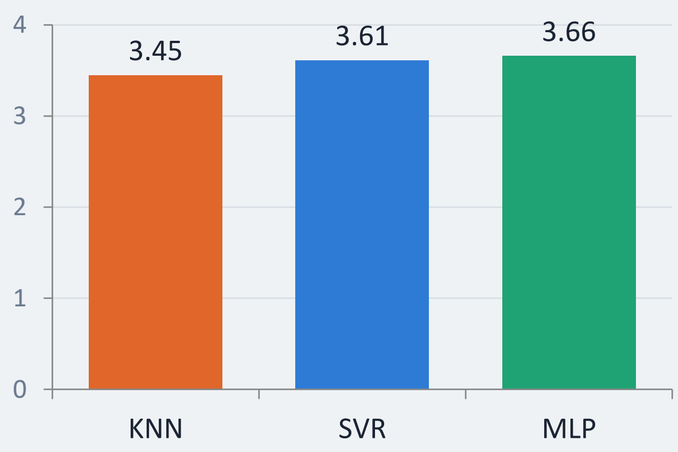
None was used in the reference study. All were tuned by 5-fold cross-validation on the 7,621 training hours.

SVR — Support vector regression
RBF kernel, C = 30, γ = 2, ε = 2 MW; CV RMSE 3.83 MW

KNN — k-nearest neighbours
k = 6, distance-weighted, Manhattan; CV RMSE 3.64 MW

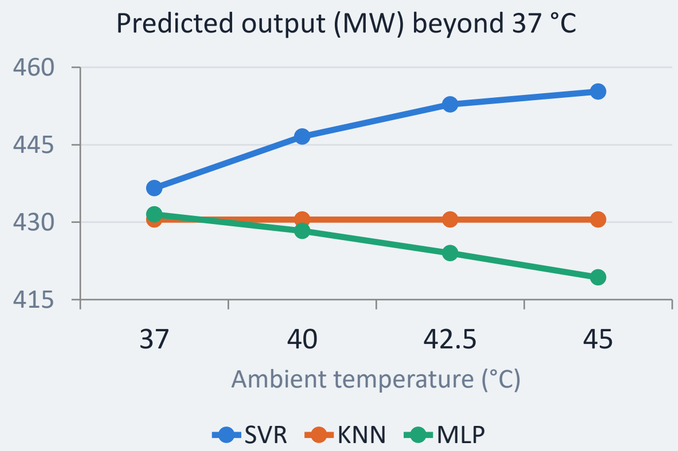
MLP — Neural network
128-128-64 ReLU, early stopping; CV RMSE 3.80 MW

5 Results on unseen hours



- All three beat the reference study (R^2 0.912, MAPE 0.872%)
- KNN's lead is significant in a paired bootstrap
- KNN over-predicts by more than 5 MW on the fewest hours: 5.3%, against 6.9% (SVR) and 7.8% (MLP)

6 Accuracy is not enough



Physics says output keeps falling with heat. The SVR predicts the opposite: 455 MW at 45 °C. No model is trusted outside its data, so the deployed model flags such hours.

7 Selected model: KNN

- Fewest costly over-predictions
- Most accurate on unseen hours
- Each prediction rests on six real past hours
- Range and density checks flag hours it cannot judge

Five new operating conditions

Case	KNN (MW)	Status
Hot afternoon, 33 °C	433.9	valid
Cold night, 6 °C	487.9	valid
Mild humid day	453.3	valid
Mild dry day	452.6	caution
Heatwave, 41 °C	429.3	flagged

8 What the model learned

−54 MW AT across its range

−10 MW V, mostly at 15 to 30 °C

−7 MW RH, dry to humid

≈ 3 MW AP, no clear direction

Accumulated local effects of the MLP match thermodynamics.

9 Two plant decisions

- Alarm when output stays more than 5.2 MW below the prediction
- Commit 2.4 MW below the prediction when a shortfall costs four times the sale price

Conclusion

Four plant measurements predict full-load output to 3.45 MW. The model beats the reference study, behaves as physics predicts, and drives an alarm and a grid safety margin.

Data: Tüfekci, P. & Kaya, H., Combined Cycle Power Plant, UCI Machine Learning Repository, CC BY 4.0, accessed 24 October 2026. Reference study: Santarisi, N. S. & Faouri, S. S. (2021), Eastern-European Journal of Enterprise Technologies, 6(8(114)), 16-26. Tools: Python, scikit-learn, Tableau Public.